

bombing

It was exactly 1pm on a warm, balmy Thursday afternoon in Melbourne, March 27th 1986. The city was packed with people on the final shopping day before Easter, and many office workers were eating their lunches in the sunshine. Up at the old police headquarters at the corner of Russell and La Trobe streets, police men and women were quietly going about their work and looking forward to the Easter break.

Suddenly, all hell broke loose, and 1pm on March 27th 1986 became a frozen moment in time that Melbourne would never forget. Welcome to Russell Street 750. Russell, 750.

750, I presume you heard that loud explosion right next to you? Russell, 750, it's totally shadowing our windows. Yeah, right there, we're about one unit from it, we'll let you know what's happening. Russell, 350, we have other units also attending from the south.

Russell, 306. Russell, 306. Russell, 306, away it explodes into a place outside the front of the complex.

We're now at the intersection of Russell Street and La Trobe Street. There's mess everywhere. A massive car bomb containing up to 50 sticks of jellignite exploded right outside one of the entrances to the police complex.

The Holden Commodore car had been parked in a police-only area just outside one of the main doors for just a few minutes before it exploded tearing itself apart and smashing windows over a wide area. The scene was total panic as injured and dazed people tried to fathom what had happened. Seconds later there was another explosion as an unmarked police car also exploded in a ball of flame.

It had been parked right behind the car bomb. And then there were more explosions. One of the first people on the scene was 3AW reporter David Langson and this was how he broke the news on 3AW moments later.

Good afternoon and welcome to another afternoon together on 3AW and before I say anything our news director Mike Fraser has just come into the studio. Sorry to interrupt your program Meryl. There have been reports of explosions outside police headquarters in Russell Street.

It only happened a few minutes ago. We've got a reporter there. David Langson, are you there? Hi Mike.

Can you describe the scene to me please? I'm at the corner of Russell Street and La Trobe Street. Windows have been blowing in at the city court hotel. There are scores of police.

The intersection has been cleared of all people. There were 5 or 6 reports of explosions. Loud explosions heard right down the end of the city.

Masses of black smoke. Ambulance and police are on the scene at the moment. Any idea the cause of the explosions, David? It was burning at the moment.

It looks like it was a massive car bomb plus a series of other explosions that might have been in that car. It is uncertain at this stage what's caused all of the explosions. And where was the car situated when it exploded? There's a mess and it's outside the Russell Street police headquarters directly across the road from the Melbourne Magistrates Court.

21 people, many of them police men and women, were taken to hospital covered in blood. But miraculously only 4 people were badly injured, 2 of them seriously. Police blocked off city intersections and waited tensely for more explosions as they began investigations into the car bomb.

A strange calm settled over Melbourne that afternoon as it gradually dawned on people that Beirut-style terrorism had come to their city for the first time. The next day was Good Friday and by dawn people around the world knew of the bomb attack on Melbourne's police force. But the police complex itself remained sealed off until late in the afternoon when 3AW reporters Jeff Harrison and Mike Fraser were allowed inside.

And that's where we take up this story. Join us for a walk through the bombed police building. It is literally a walk on the wild side.

We'll be back in a moment. The 2 of us were taken through the building by Police Media Liaison Officer Jane Munday. Here she takes up the story on the tour.

This car is the one that had the petrol bomb in it. You'll notice that part of the roof has fallen down. There's also a police sign that was on the door that's been blown backwards.

The force of the blast here knocked a girl who was sitting behind the desk here into the mess room. She was blown right through into the mess room. She was sitting... It was a public servant, wasn't it? A police woman.

And she was blowing through there. How far? She went through that school there, mid-air. 10 yards? So she was throwing 10 yards sideways into the other room.

Also, the seriously injured police woman we think was walking up these stairs. And obviously one of the big problems, you'll see it in one of the offices upstairs. It's not just the glass going around but it's all through files.

It's through valuable equipment. There's glass in the curtains. There's glass through people's books.

There's files that are open with bits of glass all through them and that's going to take years to clean up. Just moving into a secondary room now. Here as we walk, the immense amount of

glass on the floor.

This is a carpeted room and you can see here. There's a two foot sliver of glass through this chair here. There had been a public servant.

A female public servant had been sitting in the chair. She went off to get a cup of tea and while she was gone, the blast occurred. And she missed a two foot sliver of glass which has landed right where she was sitting.

It's now impaled in the chair. You see by the amount of glass here that this is one of the worst hit areas. The glass on both sides of the corridors has been blown out.

You see by the amount of glass here that this is one of the worst hit areas. The glass on both sides of the corridors has been blown out. The glass along this corridor has been trampled down a bit but you'll see it's still very thick.

And I think that the most astonishing thing about seeing this amount of glass is that people weren't hurt because it's just a carpet of glass. This here is the pistol registry which took the brunt of the blast. This floor is just covered with files, papers, things that have been blown off the desk.

There's an air conditioner there that's broken off its stem. We're in the pistol registry. That's D24 at the end of the corridor, right to the back of the building.

Now this amount of devastation continues right up to the top floor, No, the bottom floors are the worst affected. Up above here we've got the gym where there's a crack in the wall. That's the main sign of structural damage.

But the broken windows go all the way round to the back of this building in areas that weren't directly facing the blast. And round in the crime car section which is on another wing of this building we've got lights that have come out of the ceiling with the course of the blast. And the broken windows go right up to the fifth floor and even right up the top you'll see the odd broken window.

And over the road in the magistrates court you'll notice all the windows are being knocked out. There's very valuable windows that have been extensively damaged over there. This is the tunnel to the courtyard.

What sort of damage was done to the doors here at the front? Well as you can see the doors have been blown in by the strength of the explosion and we've got metal pillars that have been bent in. And this one here looks as if it's hanging off, the gates have been forced open. It's obviously been a very strong explosion.

Directly after the blast scores of police men and women inside the Russell Street complex were picking themselves off the ground wondering exactly what had happened. The force of the

explosion was so strong many police were thrown across rooms and showered with broken glass as far away as 50 metres from the car bomb. Sergeant Paul Devine was standing with his back to his office window which faces Russell Street and has a view of the Melbourne Magistrates Court.

The force of the explosion threw him across his desk. My immediate microsecond reaction was I thought I'd been shot. I felt a terrific impact but then I quickly realised that an explosion had occurred when I saw the devastation and the full extent of the noise that got through to me.

I walked out here and into the corridor and by about the time I reached this door I heard the second explosion then I heard the girl at the south door I heard her crying out and I made my way down to her and then I heard the third explosion and then some fellas grabbed me I was bleeding pretty badly and they took me across to the CIB building. I was standing here standing directly in this spot standing right here right and you were blown with your back to the window you were blown completely forward onto your hands and knees. That's right, hit the head on the desk at least I think it's the edge of the desk that I hit.

It's quite amazing that you didn't suffer more glass injuries. Yes, I was lucky. I had a lot of glass in the back of my head and hair and I've picked a few bits out of my arms but you're right, I was very lucky very lucky indeed.

I feel sorry for those other two that were badly injured. What are your feelings now? The same, exactly the same as yesterday my reaction was I was cross at the mess they'd done to our police station but just one of those things I suppose. Constable Jim Olsford used to work with the British Police Force before he came to Australia a few years ago he had extensive experience with terrorism and car bombs in particular.

He told me on this occasion the blast caused a young police woman a great deal of distress. Half an hour after the explosion I went into the crime colliders office at Russell Street which is near the north door reception desk and the place was all in darkness because the power was off and I walked in there and just looked around and I heard a voice say can I come out now and it was a sort of a timid voice a female's voice and I looked around and I saw a huddled on the floor a police woman, she was covered in blood and I thought it was her blood I didn't know and she had it on the side of her face and all over her back and I noticed blood on her ankle and I said are you alright and she said can I come out now and she said something about laying on top of a I think a policeman that had been blown up and I said are you alright and she said yes and I said well what about all this blood over here and she said that's from him and I noticed that on her left ankle she must have been cut because the stocking on the top of her left ankle was slightly into her leg you know so it looked like there was a slight indentation there and then she started shaking and crying and everything so I said come on I'll take you out to an ambulance and when she came outside and saw other people around she immediately stopped crying and said I can walk on my own and she obviously wanted to put on a brave face in front of everyone despite the terrible ordeal that she had been through and I thought she had guts to do that, to ignore what

she had gone through and try and look like she could cope for everyone that was watching. All I know is that she was a blonde policewoman but I think she deserves full credit for what she did.

The D24 Police Communications Operations Centre at Russell Street is a quiet oblong shaped room packed with thousands of dollars worth of computer and radio equipment. It's also at the front of the complex which took the full brunt of the blast. Constable Janine Stiles was the main police radio operator at the time of the blast and gave us her thoughts on Friday.

Constable Stiles, you were operating at the time of the blast, what were your immediate feelings? Somebody asked me before we were scared and I don't think we were scared of shock. We were shocked, surprised, stunned, rather a bit of disbelief. We didn't quite know what had happened, we assumed it was a bomb blast but we were just a little confused but managed to continue working I suppose.

What were your feelings directly after the blast? Much the same, they didn't really alter that much. They just you just maintain this level where you just work as best as you can but I don't think anyone was really scared as such. There was no thought of actually evacuating this room then, everyone said this is our duty and we will continue.

Honestly, I couldn't comment on that that wasn't my decision or that was a decision to be made by other people. Do you think that if you did leave that perhaps other police would be in danger? I couldn't comment on it because it just never ended my mind leaving it, I don't think anyone's mind. How much longer did you keep working? Well, we all ended up on overtime.

The afternoon shift worked till about 6 o'clock which is about 3 hours overtime and I was working till 6pm so I ended up working till 11pm. I hope you got double time. Overtime anyhow.

Much later we split the channels. On channel 36 we kept the bomb situation under our control and on another channel went all the district cars that would be handling all the normal jobs that come through. Was it 26? 36.

Councilman, was it like knowing that another bomb might go off? You had that in the back of your mind, did you? No, not until it actually did go off, no. But then it was kind of like, oh god, is there going to be a third one, then a fourth one, then a fifth one? Yeah, there's a lot of little destinations going up. While Constable Styles sounded relaxed although shaken a day after the explosion, it was quite a different story at the time.

That explosion took place outside the front of the complex. We're now at the intersection of Russell Street and Latrobe Street. There's mess everywhere.

Roger that, Russell Street 306. All units approach with caution, just in case there's a second. All units stand by on this urgent.

They go through to Russell Street 150. For 150. Russell Street 150, we just had a large explosion

occur outside the building.

Car bomb it seems, shattered all the windows at this office, received. For 150, Roger, on route, would you go to the right, 130. Roger, that goes through to Russell Street 130.

43, 306. Russell Street 306. Yeah, that car is still on fire.

Can we have the fire brigade here, please? We'll get up to the station and tell them. Yes, apparently our phones on this circuit are working. Stand by, we'll advise them.

Yeah, they're on 250. And units, the fire brigade has been advised. 150.

Russell Street 150. Russell 150, I'm at St. Kilda Road, Embassy area, it's going to take me some time to get there because of the traffic. There's 130 now in the situation.

There's been a second explosion, units stay away from the area. We've got Russell Street 306 in particular, keep cleared area for the moment, thank you. Russell 150, we're getting into a touch with Melbourne District traffic, have them control traffic, block the whole area from La Trobe to Victoria, over.

I think we're in 307 within. We'll take La Trobe. Unit taking La Trobe.

7, 8, 7, we'll be about 200 or so yards down from Russell Street, blocking all traffic. Watch that down near La Trobe, is it? Somebody will keep it tight from this end. This is Geoff Harrison.

In a moment, Mike Fraser will be back to end this report. It was a scene which reminded me of days in Vietnam during the war there. Glass, blood, wreckage and terror, and now it has arrived in my home town.

As a young police reporter many years ago, I used to leave my car parked outside D24 all night, and never thought twice about it. Those days went forever at 1pm on Thursday. From now on, any unknown car parked outside any police station will create tense suspicion, if not a full alert.

Walking through the D24 building, it was obvious that the person who set this bomb did it to kill police, to kill many police. It was a huge bomb which blew in many windows, creating showers of deadly, flying glass shrapnel. I saw some things which sent a shiver down my spine.

A handkerchief spaded with blood, a long sliver of glass embedded into the seat of a chair, desks covered in glass, a ripped police badge. It was a miracle that no one was killed outright. The car containing the bomb was placed right at the front of the building, just feet from a 6,600 volt electricity substation, which is on the ground floor.

Only God knows the result if that substation had gone up too. The explosion not only changed the face of that old building, it changed the face of Melbourne itself. No longer will we be able to walk

through the streets without a worry in the world.

Until the person or persons who carried out this insane act of court, we are all in danger. Ironically, the first senior officer on the scene at 1pm Thursday was Superintendent Ian McLeigh. He'd been upstairs eating his lunch and reading a book about bombings and terrorism.

Now he has some first-hand knowledge of it, and don't we all. This is Mike Fraser.